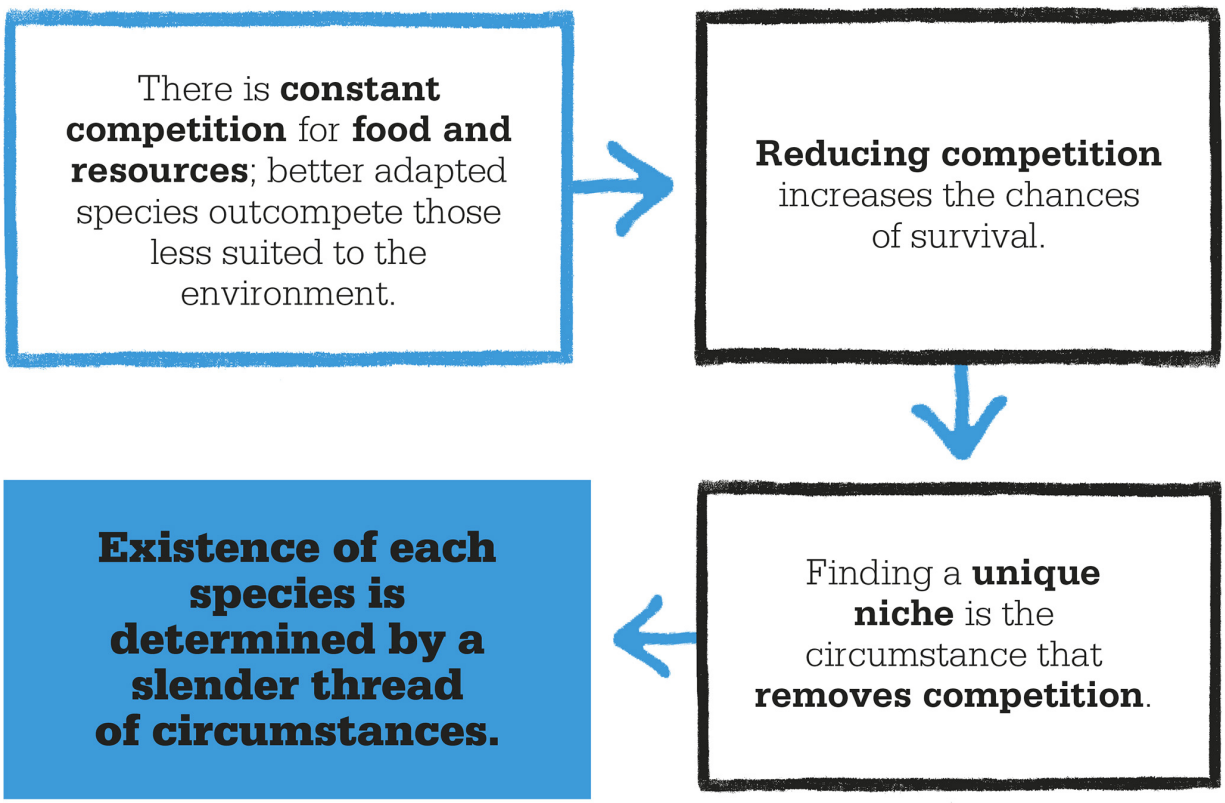


Read accessible description

Widening the niche

In the 1920s, ecologist Charles Elton looked beyond a simple habitat definition for "niche." For him, what an animal ate and what it was eaten by were the primary factors. Thirty years later, George Evelyn Hutchinson expanded the definition yet further. He argued that a niche should take into account all of an organism's interactions with other organisms and its nonliving environment, including geology, acidity of soil or water, nutrient flows, and climate. Hutchinson's work encouraged others to explain the variety of resources used by a single organism (niche breadth), the ways in which competing species coexist (niche partitioning), and the overlap of resources by different animals and plants (niche overlap).